A further Indian involvement in World War II concerned the Indian National Army (INA). In 1941, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose sought assistance first from the Soviet Union, then Nazi Germany, before reviving the INA with Japanese assistance in Southeast Asia. The INA, made up of prisoners of war from Malaya and Singapore, among others, fought alongside Japanese forces in the Burma theatre. As Japanese forces retreated, Bose died in a plane crash in Formosa (today's Taiwan) in 1945. [81] The divided Indian approach to World War II revealed itself in criticism within the Congress and among some of its political opponents of the Quit India Movement, during which Gandhi urged the Congress to call for British withdrawal from India even as the war was underway. [82] The defence by Congress leaders—including specifically Jawaharlal Nehru—of INA officers in high-profile trials highlights the complex attitudes in India to World War II.

Beyond the military, the employment of Indian manpower by the British Empire in a variety of overseas conditions was immense and varied. As the Viceroy Lord Curzon boasted in a speech in 1904, '[I]f you are fighting the Mad Mullah in Somaliland, you soon discover that Indian troops and an Indian general are best qualified for the task, and you ask the Government of India to send them; if you desire to defend any of your extreme outposts or coaling stations of the Empire, Aden, Mauritius, Singapore, Hong-kong, even Tien-tsin or Shan-hai-kwan, it is to the Indian Army that you turn . . . It is with . . . Indian trained officers that you irrigate Egypt and dam the Nile; with Indian forest officers that you tap the resources of Central Africa and Siam; with Indian surveyors that you explore all the hidden places of the earth.' [83]

The colonial period also directly influenced India's state structures and physical boundaries. To the north and west, British competition with the Russian Empire—the so-called 'Great Game'—played an important role. (Russia was viewed by Indian nationalists as no less an imperial power; many Indians celebrated Russia's defeat in the Russo–Japanese War.) As a process of British expansion and frontier competition, a series of legal treaties were established between British India and its neighbours that